Designing a Gamified Application for User Privacy Preference Extraction

Continual Assessment Report

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Background

Even in this day and age of absurd technological advancements, user privacy preference remains an alien topic for the general public. There are several ways user privacy preferences can be collected online, some common ways that are used may be through surveys [1], device settings parsing [2], and cookies' consent banner interaction [3]. This project will specifically be exploring how user privacy preferences are extracted through cookies, commonly presented to users with the interface of a popup provided by CMPs (Consent Management Platforms) called cookie banners [4] each time they visit a website. These cookie banners would then request permissions from users to indicate their consent preferences for cookies, which are small blocks of data placed on the user's device that allows the websites to store stateful information regarding the user or the user's browsing activity [5].

Most people don't really pay close attention to the user privacy preferences that they (have to) set each time they visit a new website on the Internet and is presented with a cookie banner. Whenever people are presented with a popup-like interface with verbose texts that they have to read through, the instinct for most people would be to get rid of the popup window [6]. As such when combined with the assumption that the general public isn't sufficiently educated on the topic of the importance of user privacy preferences and how to manage them well, users tend to click the options presented on the interface that allows them to proceed immediately (i.e. usually the "Accept All" or "Deny All" options). Some reasons why people tend to ignore how user privacy preference extraction works in cookie banners is likely driven by the cookie banners' deliberately complex design and users' knowledge limitations [7].

In view of this problem presented and potential causes that are established, this project aims to solve this issue by gamifying the process of user privacy preference extraction through cookie banners.

1.2 Project Objectives

Given the background of the project, the project aims to address the problems through primarily 3 objectives:

1. Investigate existing solutions that attempts to address similar issues
2. Design a solution that presents the management of cookies in a gamified interface
3. Evaluate how a gamified process may be effective in helping users manage their privacy preferences within their own initiative

Chapter 2

Ideation of Solution

Before constructing the ideation of this project's solution, it is useful to understand where the current common practices stands, specifically how do most websites collect user's cookies consent preferences.

2.1 Review of Current Cookie Consent Practices

As mentioned briefly in the introduction of the report, most websites currently uses specialized tools called Consent Management Platforms (CMPs) to help them log user's consensual choices for cookies that their websites will be using [8]. In the form of popups, user will be asked to indicate their preferences whenever they visit a website that their browser does not have cached data recording their privacy preference choices for the cookies.

2.1.1 Exhibit A: F1 Official Website

We will be taking the F1 official website [9] as an example of how this looks practically. Upon entering the website for the first time, users are greeted with the popup window shown in Figure 2.1.

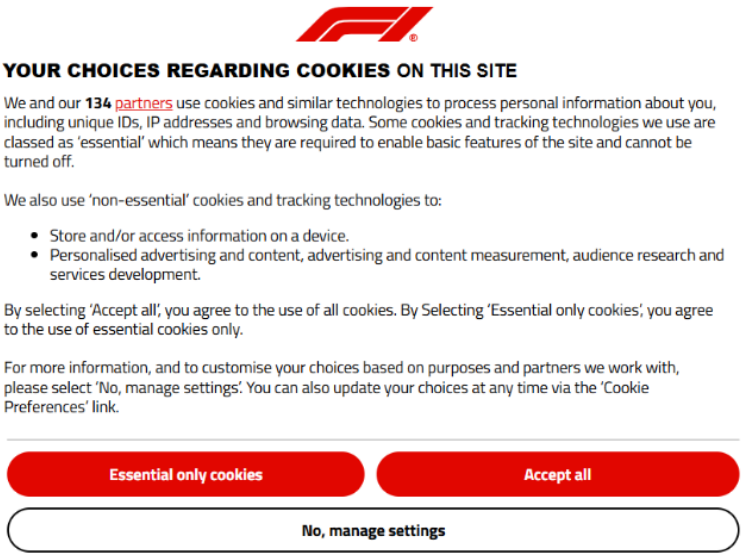


Figure 2.1: Cookie consent banner displayed on the F1 official website.

Users are presented with mainly 3 choices on the interface, one to accept only essential cookies, one to accept all, and the last one is to have more autonomy and manually manage

settings for cookie consent choices. Observe how even though details regarding the cookies and what they are mainly used for is explicitly written on the interface, it is presented in a way that may seem overly verbose and irrelevant for the common public to understand. In addition, the options that are highlighted in red will also appeal more towards the user, which causes users to make choices that subject themselves to consent more cookies. This is a common practice among most websites known as dark patterns, that attempt to use manipulative UX designs to force user into making choices that often benefits the company behind [10].

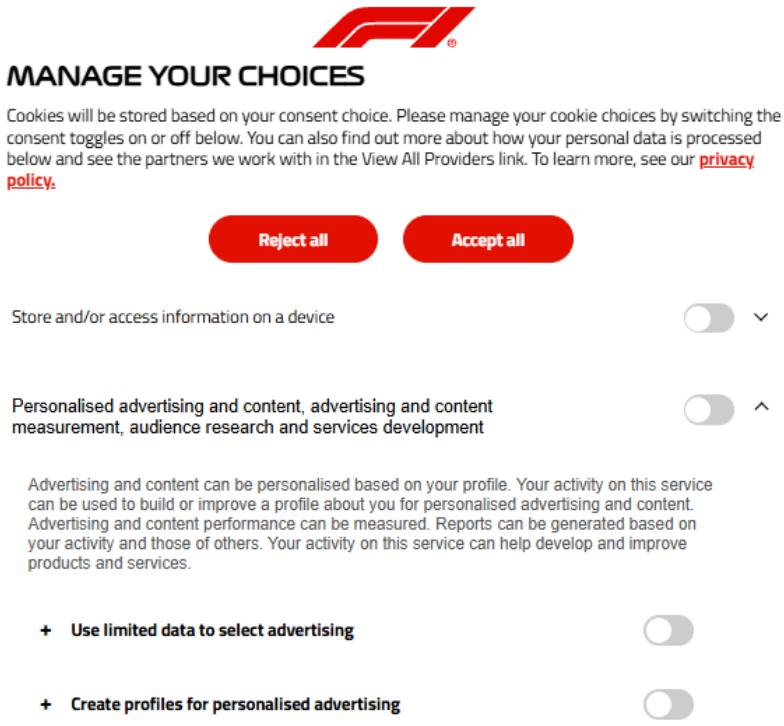


Figure 2.2: Cookie banner 'manage settings' window of F1 official website.

Upon clicking the 'No, manage settings' option, user can further indicate their preference for which purpose their collected data from the cookies can be used. The usage of cookies are split into different ways data collected through cookies can be used, such as to select advertising, or to create profiles for personalised advertising, as shown in Figure 2.2. Though the user is able to have more autonomy, this also adds to the problem of a complex privacy preference extraction process as user has to go through each options to decide whether they want to consent to it or not.

2.1.2 Exhibit B: Fifa Official Website

Another example that we can look at is from the Fifa Official Website [11]. Similarly, they have a cookie banner for the user to indicate their privacy preference through 3 buttons as shown in Figure 2.3.



Figure 2.3: Cookie consent banner displayed on the Fifa official website.

If the user were to click the preference center option marked in white, the user would then be greeted with another interface as such under Figure 2.4. Cookies that can be consented such

as functional cookies are all compiled into one window in the privacy preference center interface. This may seem easier for the users to customize their privacy preference, it took away some autonomy from the user when they can't consent at a deeper level where they consent only to certain functional cookies instead of all functional cookies as a whole, comparatively to F1's cookie banner in Figure 2.2 where user is able to indicate preference for each cookies' purpose. However, this is significantly more concise and easy for the user to go through.

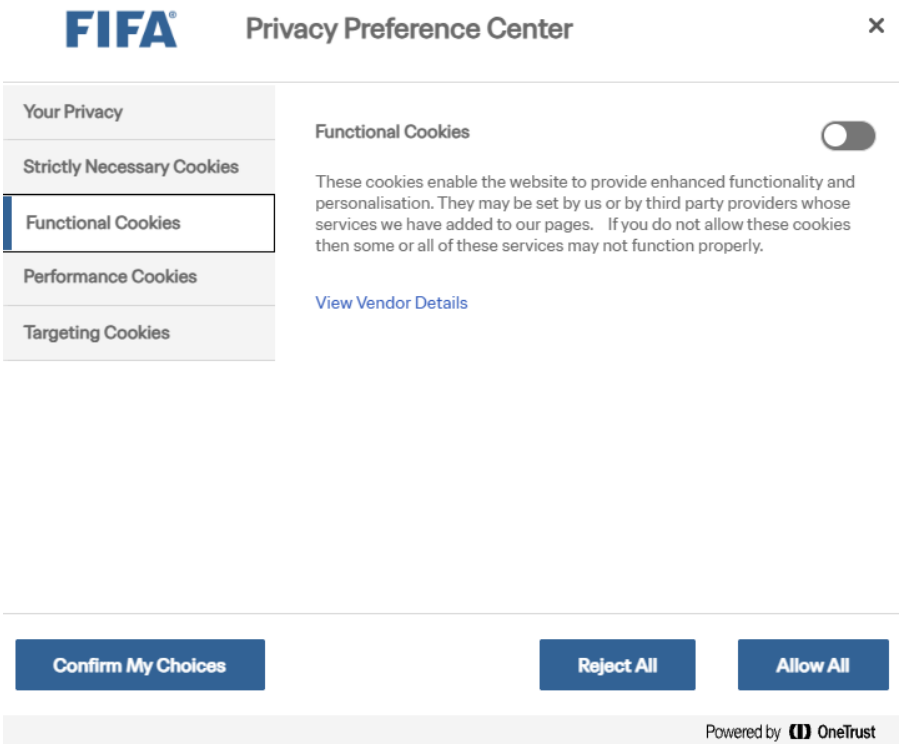


Figure 2.4: Privacy Preference Center of Fifa official website.

2.2 Requirements

After reviewing the common cookie consent preference extraction practices of websites, we can come up with 5 requirements of how our solution should look like in order to solve the problems found above.

1. Concise

   Users shouldn't be looking at verbose content to understand the implication of their privacy preference choices, confusion should be avoided.

2. Convenient

   User should be able to easily access and set up the application.

3. Engaging

   Users should be engaged during the process of privacy preference extraction.

4. Informative

   Provides sufficient information to the user on how their privacy preferences affects them.

5. User-centric autonomous

   Users should be able to have as much control as possible to their own cookie consent privacy preference.

2.3 Constructing the Solution

A privacy companion that appears when you visit websites, explains what privacy choices are being requested, and turns privacy decisions into an interactive scenario-based experience.

2.3.1 Notion

User privacy preference is a subject that each user passes by everyday as they visit different websites, yet most people ignore it. There are multiple reasons as to why this happens, but the most prominent and straightforward reason that users tend to overlook it is that the current way of presenting it is boring, verbose and inconvenient, encountering dozens of such popups would be mentally tiring for users [7]. Hence, the topic of designing a gamified application to represent the simulation of managing each user's own privacy preference aims to solve the issue of the current method of extracting these preferences from users. The intrinsic details of user privacy preferences can be simplified and become more approachable for users. A visual representation of everything is useful to engage the user while presenting each cookie, third-parties, privacy preferences etc. in a new way that catches the attention of the user.

2.3.2 The 'Home' analogy

As browsing the internet and different websites is just like visiting different people's homes, instead of presenting websites and cookies as technical terms, websites can be described as homes that users visit and the cookies are like guests in the home. Subsequently, they can be personified according to the purpose of each cookies. For example, authentication cookies that let websites recognizes users can be presented as the owner (company) of the home (website) wants to remember the user's name so that the user can re-enter their home anytime [12]. This usage of analogy can then be presented as different scenarios that the user has to go through to indicate their privacy preferences for cookies.

However, if the user wants to know more about specific cookies, the application retains the option for users to read the original details of the cookies without the analogy being applied and presented as scenario-based questions. In other words, in the form of the original cookie banner consent interface.

2.3.3 Chatbot interface

When presented with different scenario-based questions, there are nuances that the user might be restricted to if a similar approach of binary choices presented by cookie banners is used. We have to acknowledge that there are deeper levels to every user's privacy preference. For that, an approach to allow users to respond with natural language would be able to help users to express their privacy preferences better. Hence, this project uses a chatbot interface for the users to communicate with the application, which would then translate the user's answers into decisions.

2.3.4 Dynamic questions

As each websites use different cookies and request different consent permissions from the user, a fixed pool of scenario-based questions would not suffice to cover every cookies. This calls for the need of a way to generate dynamic scenario-based questions depending on the cookies.

The solution would have to take in some input regarding the details of each cookies and what their purpose is, and generate these questions accordingly for users to go through. Additionally, dynamic questions can serve as clarifying questions and be used to rectify any ambiguity that may surface when users give unclear answers that require more information from the user in order to be translated into deterministic privacy preference decisions.

2.3.5 Translation from user answers into decisions

Answers received from users through the chatbot as they go through the scenario-based questions would then be processed in backend to be translated into a deterministic decision made by the user. The decision would be applied through the application and be communicated with the CMPs to indicate user's privacy preferences.

2.3.6 Accessibility and Appearance

The solution would have to be easy for users to set up and use, hence an application that can be accessed as a simple browser extension would be ideal for our solution. Through this extension, the application should be able to collect cookie data, interact with users, and communicate with CMPs of each websites. Furthermore, the application would also have some kind of visual representation of their current privacy preferences, in the form of analogies mentioned under section 2.3.2.

2.3.7 Addressing the Requirements

Given the ideation of solution above, we can conclude how these aspects address the requirements that was established previously:

1. Conciseness

   The application filters out verbose words and simplifies them into scenario questions.

2. Conveniency

   Easily accessed via installing a browser extension. Users can interact with the extension in the same window and same tab as the websites.

3. Engagement

   With the help of visual representation and chatbot interface, the application presents the concept of privacy preferences and cookies with analogies to make it more interesting and immersive.

4. Informativity

   Always the option available for the user to know more about the details, this will make the application less concise but is optional for the user.

5. User-centric Autonomy

   Users can change their preferences anytime by interacting with the chatbot.

2.4 Constraints

There are several constraints and concerns regarding the application that can be foresee at this stage of development.

2.4.1 Requesting permissions

Accessing certain cookies' data requires the application to ask for permissions from the user. While developing the application, it is important to be careful in how the application handles requesting permission from the user and should be mindful of not requesting more permissions than necessary.

2.4.2 Supporting limited CMPs

Different websites use different CMPs and different cookies. The current ideation of the solution would be heavily limited by the breadth of how much CMPs it can support (i.e. communicate with) as they have distinct APIs and categories for cookies. This project would be aiming to support one of the CMPs named CookieBot [13].

2.4.3 Handling data safely

Messages from the user to the chatbot would be sent to an external natural language AI model service, the application has to navigate the handling of these data safely such that user's private information isn't leaked to external sources. Users should be told that this is the case and should avoid entering sensitive personal information when interacting with the chatbot.

2.4.4 Natural language misinterpretation

Natural language responses from users will be subjected to the risk of being ambiguous or unclear, which may lead to misinterpretation from the natural langauge model of exactly what the user wants to express. Clarifying questions must be asked in order to establish a firm understanding of user's decision. The application has to take a stance of taking no actions until it is certain of the user's intention.

Chapter 3

Literature Review

3.1 CookieBlock: Automating Cookie Consent and GDPR Violation Detection

Among other works and solutions that strive to solve similar problems as this project does, is "CookieBlock: Automating Cookie Consent and GDPR Violation Detection" [14]. The similar points between CookieBlock and this project is how CookieBlock takes in input and classifies cookies into different categories. CookieBlock trained their own classifier with concrete mappings between cookies and their purposes, and used this classifier to identify cookies and categorize them to decide whether or not they fit the user's privacy preferences, and should be accepted or denied. CookieBlock trained their own classifier to predict the purposes of each cookie by looking at attributes of the cookies, such as: name, domain, path, etc. to extract different features and be used in machine learning. CookieBlock is also a solution that takes on the form of a browser extension, something this project aims to become in view of convenience for users.

3.2 Research gap and implications for this project

On the other hand, this project will be taking inputs such as the browser cookie metadata, CMP signals, and cookie-purpose mappings to categorize cookies and integrate them into scenario-based questions via the analogy's personification. Contrary to CookieBlock where it is stated that cookie-to-purpose mapping in websites' privacy policy is generally not useful as the policy varies across websites, this project is able to ignore this concern as we've limited the project's capacity to support only CookieBot's cookie declaration format and will be able to scan websites' HTML for such declarations [15], [16].

In order to achieve the goal of presenting users with dynamic scenarios that they can run through, it is integral for this project to have concrete cookie-to-purpose mappings. While this project's goal isn't focused on correctly classifying each cookie's purpose live, we took on a limitation, relying on the Cookiebot's scanned database to look up each cookie's purposes instead of trying to achieve the goal of identifying each cookie's purpose on any arbitrary websites, which will be using all kinds of CMPs. Instead, this project focuses on the idea of extracting user preferences using a natural language interface between the user and an agent that presents dynamic privacy-related scenarios disguised in a more digestible analogy. This project will then explore the topic on how this approach can smoothen the privacy preference extraction process and elevates users' interest in cookie consent management through gamified engagements, which is a question that CookieBlock only addressed indirectly.

Chapter 4

Progress to Date

4.1 Work completed

The project has shown progress in the aspect of realizing privacy choices into the 'Home' analogy mentioned under section 2.3.2. This is achieved with the implementation of mainly two features: a browser cookie data adapter and an implementation of the 'Home' analogy interface. The combination of these two features allows the application to generate dynamic scenario-based questions based on cookie data collected from the adapter for users to go through.

4.1.1 Browser extension adapter

In order to implement a system where dynamic scenarios can be generated based on each cookies' purpose, the necessity of a cookie input adapter is integral to the project. Without an interpreter standardizing each cookie's metadata, their CMP signal data, and categorizing them into different purpose, the project can't present dynamic text-based scenarios for the user, which means that it can't fulfill the purpose of extracting user's privacy preferences at all.

With the implementation of an adapter in the form of a browser extension, the project is now able to collect cookie data from websites that use CookieBot as their CMP. The data that the extension collects includes:

1. Cookie metadata: describes cookie properties such as its name, lifespan, security attributes, and scope. These properties indicate how the cookie may be stored, transmitted, and when it expires [17], [18].

2. CMP signal data: records the user's existing consent choices for categories of cookies on the website [19].

3. Public cookie declaration: a published list of cookie-purpose mapping for cookies used on the website [20].

After collecting these information, the adapter would be able to map each cookies detected to a purpose through the public cookie declaration (if available) and be categorized.

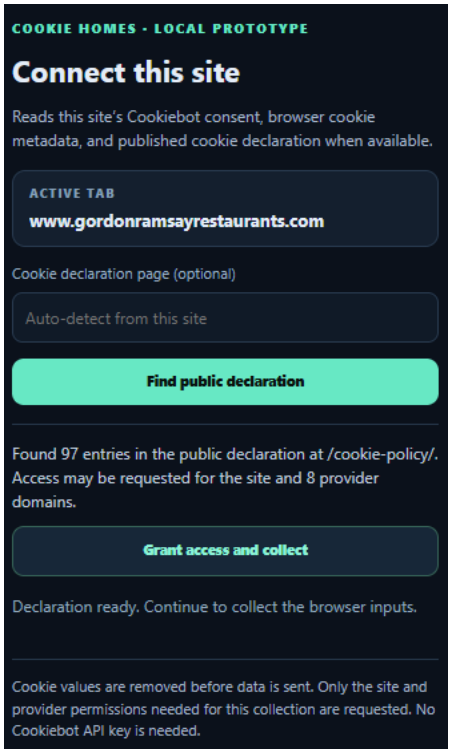


Figure 4.1: A browser extension cookie data adapter.

4.1.2 'Home' analogy interface

With a concrete cookie-purpose mapping, the application is able to personify each cookies as a 'guest' in the 'Home' analogy under section 2.3.2.

4.2 Design or investigation alternatives

[Present plausible alternatives and compare them against clear criteria. A table can help.]

Table 4.1: Example comparison of alternatives (replace with your own).

Criterion	Alternative A	Alternative B
[Criterion]	[Evidence / trade-off]	[Evidence / trade-off]

4.3 Challenges and risks

[Explain issues encountered and what you did or will do about them.]

Chapter 5

Research Plan for Next Semester

5.1 Planned work and methods

[List the remaining activities, methods, tools, and expected outputs.]

5.2 Milestones

Table 5.1: Provisional next-semester plan. Replace weeks with actual dates.

Period	Activity	Output
Weeks 1–2	[Refine design / protocol]	[Approved plan]
Weeks 3–5	[Build / collect / investigate]	[Intermediate result]
Weeks 6–8	[Evaluate / analyze]	[Evaluation findings]
Weeks 9–12	[Refine and write up]	[Final report / demonstration]

5.3 Evaluation and success criteria

[State how you will judge whether objectives have been met and what evidence you will collect.]

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Acknowledgement of AI Use

I used OpenAI Codex (GPT-6) to help prepare the LaTeX report template and format the document, including arranging and sizing figures. I also used it to generate ideas, suggest and refine wording, review grammar, explain project-related concepts, and identify relevant online sources. I reviewed and edited its suggestions and take responsibility for the accuracy, quality, and final content of this report. I also used it to help me write this declaration of AI use in my CA report.